

Come As You Are

Allow approximately one hour, or longer if needed. This is not a timed exercise. Take breaks and move at your own pace. Nothing here is graded. A blank line is an honest answer.

1 • Check-in

Answer briefly. This is a check-in, not a test.

1. How is your body right now? Tired, restless, tense, heavy, numb, calm? Name it without fixing it.

2. How is your mind? Racing, foggy, anxious, blank, quietly sad?

3. What speech have you prepared? In other words, what have you been planning to prove, achieve, or perform during these days so that the retreat will count?

4. Look back at your Lesson 4 check-in. Does it still describe you today? What has changed since you wrote it, if anything?

3 • Your intention

Read the intention you wrote in Lesson 7 to God, exactly as you wrote it. If anything has changed, note it here.

4 • Silence

Anchor phrase: "While he was still a long way off, his father saw him." Or: "I am here."

5 • Journal

1. What did you notice during the silence? Thoughts, feelings, physical sensations, nothing in particular. Write it down without interpreting it.

2. The father ran. What is your honest reaction to the idea that God is not waiting for you to arrive properly, but is already moving toward you in compassion? Relief, suspicion, disbelief, indifference? Write the true answer.

3. The son planned to be a servant rather than a son. Where in your life, or your faith, have you been trying to be useful instead of being received?

4. Finish this sentence, and do not think about it too long: "The thing I most need to tell God honestly at the start of this retreat is..."

6 • Setting things down

Bring into the retreat (grief, anger, questions, relationships that need prayer, your intention):

Set aside until the end (routine work, non-urgent emails, errands, decisions that can wait). Copy these onto cards, seal them in an envelope, and write your plan's words on the front:

Your plan	Write on the envelope
Three-day retreat (also couples, pastors, and a weekend group)	Not until Day 3
One-day retreat	Not until the end of today
Three-hour reset	Not for these three hours
At-home retreat, eight or twelve days	Not until my final retreat session
Weekly church group	Not until our final session

7 • Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. If a line feels beyond you, change "I" to "I want to believe," "I am willing to consider," or "Help me receive."

I have come as I am.

I am seen from a long way off, with compassion.

I do not have to earn these days.

During this retreat, I will practise laying down performance, and I will begin learning a different way to live when I return.

The envelope is for ordinary demands only. A safety concern, a medical need, a crisis, thoughts of harming yourself, or an urgent responsibility are not placed in the envelope to wait; handle them now.